PREPARE TO WIN

How a world champion thinks, leads and builds winning teams

HARRIE KWINTEN

Prepare to Win – Doing Is the Best Way of Thinking
The Practical Method for Leadership, Performance Culture and Commercial Effectiveness

Harrie Kwinten
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Together, these four playing fields form a framework with which organisations not only can better think, but especially better can perform.

PART

I

THE MINDSET OF PREPARE TO WIN

CHAPTER

01

WHY ELITE SPORT AND BUSINESS ARE THE SAME ARENA

STATEMENT

> *Anyone who truly understands elite sport knows that winning never starts with the scoreboard, but with the standard you demand of yourself every day.*

At first glance, elite sport and business seem like two different worlds. The game of sport is played on a field, in a stadium or in an arena. The game of business is played in offices, boardrooms, customer conversations and markets that constantly change.

Look closely and you see that the laws of performance in both worlds are strikingly similar. In both worlds, it ultimately comes down to the same thing: being ready when it matters most.

Key aspects include: performing under pressure, staying focused when others drop off, and continuing to improve when success tempts you to become complacent.

As a former elite athlete, I have experienced first-hand what it takes to perform at a high level.

Not once, but time and time again.

This requires more than talent. Talent helps, but it is never enough.

insight into the decision-making process, poor follow-up, or unclear roles and responsibilities.

In elite sport, no one would say: we worked hard enough and were active enough, so it was a good game. What matters there is the quality of execution. In business, we should set the bar just as high.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. / Where in our organisation do we mistake busyness for performance?
2. Which talents remain underutilized because we do not spend enough time developing the right behaviours?
3. What are we good at talking about, but not yet good enough at putting into practice?

An important difference between good intentions and real performance is that intentions often remain verbal, while performance always becomes visible in behaviour. In organisations, you regularly hear that people want to become more customer-focused, sharper or more entrepreneurial. But the question is never whether people want that. The question is whether daily routines also enforce, support and correct that behaviour.

In elite sport, no one improves simply by saying they want to get better. A training schedule is put in place, performance is measured, progress is reviewed, adjustments are made, and then the process is practiced again. That very simplicity is missing in many organisations. They have ambition, but no training rhythm. They have goals, but no clear standards of behaviour. They have meetings, but too little correction of how things are actually executed.

That is why the comparison with elite sport is so valuable. Not because business should become a competition stripped of humanity, but because elite sport shows that high performance is only sustainable when people know what is expected of them and are willing to keep developing themselves accordingly.

What is often underestimated in this context is the value of repetition. In sport, repetition is not seen as a lack of inspiration, but as the path to reliability. In business, people are often quicker to look for something new, while the answer frequently lies in executing what they already know more effectively. An organisation that matures in this respect creates calm rather than noise.

It also requires a different language. Less talk about busyness, more about progress. Less about good intentions, more about observable behaviour. Less about talent, more about the ability to develop through training. That language makes performance concrete and helps leaders not only to inspire, but also to correct where necessary.

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE

Imagine an organisation that presents an ambitious growth plan. The strategy works on paper, the market seems attractive and the people are capable. Nevertheless, the result lags behind. Not because the plan is bad, but because daily execution has not been trained. Customer conversations are prepared inconsistently, follow-up depends entirely on personal discipline and feedback comes only when a quarter disappoints. The problem then lies not in ambition, but in performance behaviour.

An elite sports coach would not start with a new challenge in a situation like this. They would look at the training. What happens every week? Which standards are repeated? Where are corrections made? Who takes ownership when things get difficult? Translating those questions into a business context creates a much more honest picture of the organisation's true performance capacity.

The lesson is clear: anyone who wants to improve consistently must look not only at strategy, but also at how people prepare, execute, evaluate, and recover every day. That is where elite sport and business truly come together.
